

Baring THE TRUTH

INDIA TODAY's sixth sex survey shows a more sexually carnivorous urban Indian willing to break taboos and batter boundaries. But the appetite is clearly greater than the menu.

By Kaveree Bamzai

It's perhaps appropriate. In the age of universal meltdown, India seems to be a nation in heat. Take what just happened in Meerut. A young woman, Priyanka Singh a former beauty queen, well-spoken, smart, goes on camera to plead her case after being accused of killing her parents. She and her friend, Anju Singh, hint at a murky saga of sexual exploitation by their relatives and talk of being driven to the edge of a breakdown. Prise the lid off India's gleaming globalised façade and a welter of images comes forth. There's a woman in Mumbai chopping her boyfriend into pieces with her former lover. There's a teenager mysteriously murdered in her Noida home amidst murmurs of her

parents' swinging sexual lifestyle. If social norms are changing, with the touchstones of modern life under siege, then sexual mores are in a state of confusion.

What was considered a perversion earlier is a guiltless pleasure now. What was thought of a taboo is now believed to be an all access VIP pass. Even the terminology, loaded with the prudishness of the past, is being reinvented. Is adultery the same as infidelity? Does kinky sex just mean prolonged foreplay? The INDIA TODAY-AC Nielsen-MARG sex survey 2008 of 5,353 men and women between 18 and 40, the sixth consecutive time we are studying the intimate life of

urban Indians, seems to suggest all this and more. The seven deadly taboos, kinky sex, homosexuality, adultery, incest, underage sex, prostitution and pornography, are no longer regarded as out of bounds. Approval rates for everything considered censorious are high. Twenty-six per cent (more men at 43 per cent than women at 8 per cent) think sex outside a long-term relationship is acceptable, especially with those close at hand like friends and neighbours. Sixteen per cent are fine with homosexuality. Almost 20 per cent of the male respondents have had sex with prostitutes, some even sharing the experience, while 28 per

ALL PHOTOGRAPHS USED IN THE SEX SURVEY HAVE BEEN SHOT WITH PROFESSIONAL MODELS.

Photographs by BANDEEP SINGH, Location Courtesy THE AMBASSADOR HOTEL, NEW DELHI